For East Germans, the appeal of West German television, with its glamorous dramas, Heimat films, uncensored news and Western soaps, was obvious. The two GDR state channels were bereft of modern programming and even ceased running commercials in 1976 after a Honecker-inspired purge on the advertising industry. Tuning to the West, East Germans were especially fond of Dalli Dalli, a lively knockabout quiz aired on ZDF. With mischievous casualness, host Hans Rosenthal announced the broadcast dates on the first show of every season, especially for East German viewers with no access to TV guide magazines. By the same token, the BBC attracted scores of teenage fans in the GDR with their Records al la Carte show, in which full-length songs were played so listeners could record them on cassette and build a personal collection of Western hits. AFN, the American Forces Network in West Berlin out-foxed other channels by playing popular music through the night, long after the GDR network had signed-off air.

The ninth Congress also highlighted the urgent need to upgrade newspapers which remained poor in both terms of language and content, though given most were organs of SED opinion rather than newspapers, this is not surprising. Though articles were rarely signed, the style of each feature was almost identical. (On one occasion, Neues Deutschland printed Honecker's official portrait forty times in a single edition).

A notable success for East German state TV was when it held millions of viewers spellbound during the summer of 1976 with live coverage of the thrilling exploits of the GDR Olympic squad. In all, the team won a scoop of medals at the Montreal Games, including forty golds, second only to the Soviet Union. 'The miracle that you hear about in the face of the success of our athletes in every corner of the world is no secret. It is called socialism,' Honecker beamed. As was his wont, he became very absorbed in the drama, rarely missing the TV coverage.

Only with the fall of the GDR was the widely held suspicion confirmed that East Germany's success in international athletics and swimming was fuelled by one of the most elaborate – and successful – doping schemes in history. Between 1964 and 1990, Manfred Ewald, a close friend of Honecker,